gather at a single temple, a prayer group goes from monastery to monastery, performing a shorter version of the full ceremony at every stop.

The Chinese accounts are silent on how many monks stayed away from, or disagreed with, all this ritual and idol worship, which the Buddha had expressly warned against. He had clearly overestimated the ability of his flock to live without the symbolic and emotional immediacy of having his image close at hand. Like most of us, the monks were good at compartmentalizing ideas. In a competitive marketplace of faiths, embracing such rituals and idol worship likely also made it easier to attract new converts.

Monasteries run their own kitchens, writes Yijing. Outside each kitchen is a wooden statue of Mahakala, a Tantric deity seated on a small chair and darkened with oil rubbings. He allays misfortunes from people's lives. At meal times, incense is burned and food is first offered to Mahakala. Oil lamps are lit after dark. During dinner, monks sit on low rattan chairs with wickerwork, about 18 inches apart to avoid touching each other while eating, which is said to be defiling; junior monks might sit on low blocks of wood. Trays of food are then brought out and placed before them on the ground, a surface typically made of dried cow dung and leaves.

Dinner begins with a welcome serving of one or two pieces of ginger with salt on a leaf. Next might be 'gruel made of dried rice and bean soup with hot butter sauce as flavoring, which is to be mixed with the other food [using] fingers'. Vegetables might follow, perhaps also ghee, honey, sugar, cereal cake or a seasonal fruit like mango. Vegetables are not eaten raw and are 'well cooked and eaten after mixing with asafoetida, clarified butter, oil, or any spice'. On other days, the monks might get different items: boiled barley and peas, baked 'cornflour', various roots, stalks, leaves, flowers, fruits or even meat—as long as the meat is not commissioned for them (it was okay to consume leftover meat that was donated to them, or came from an animal who died naturally or in an accident).[*] A complex taxonomy forbids certain foods to be mixed with others during a meal. Only the right hand is used for eating. Copper utensils are preferred but single-use earthenware utensils are also employed on special occasions, creating piles of discarded vessels similar to the piles of *kulhar* chai cups we associate with Indian train stations.